Mesa
SCHOOL OF BUSINESS

BYOB CHALLENGE · WORKSHOP 2 · JULY 2026

Sourcing Mastery

The Indian D2C playbook — finding, vetting and ordering from your first supplier.

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AGENDA

What we'll cover today.

01 Where to Source
India's supplier ecosystem — and where to start.

02 Discover & Vet
Building a shortlist you can trust.

03 Contact, Sample & Order
From first email to inventory in hand.

04 Your Mission
A 10-day sourcing sprint.

ONCE YOUR IDEA IS CHOSEN

The real challenge begins: execution.

How do you find a supplier you can **trust**?

How do you avoid getting **cheated**?

How do you verify **quality** before you commit?

GLOSSARY

Eight terms to speak the language.

MOQ	Minimum Order Quantity — the smallest number of units a supplier will make in a single order.
Lead Time	Time from placing an order to the goods arriving — plan your launch date around it.
Sample	A single production unit you order before bulk, to verify quality, material and finish.
TrustSEAL	IndiaMart's verification badge — signals a supplier has passed basic background checks.
GST	Goods & Services Tax registration — a valid GSTIN is proof a supplier is a real, compliant business.
PO	Purchase Order — the written record of product, price, terms and timeline you agree with a supplier.
Wholesaler	A seller of ready, standardized stock in bulk — faster and lower-MOQ than a manufacturer.
Landed Cost	The true cost of one unit after product cost, shipping, duties and taxes are added.

THE SOURCING PLAYBOOK

The Sourcing Playbook

Finding — and vetting — your first supplier.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Build local, buy local.

An 8-week sprint

Success means leveraging India's own vast supplier ecosystem — no time for imports.

Your focus

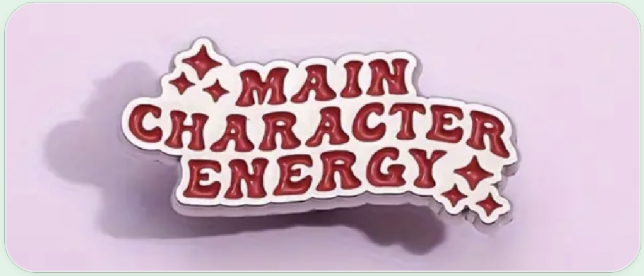
Indian suppliers, domestic manufacturing, and local service providers.

Why it works

Faster turnaround, easier troubleshooting, and **lower working capital** needs.

SOURCED & MADE IN INDIA







WHERE SHOULD YOU FIND SUPPLIERS?

Start where speed and trust meet.

IndiaMart / TradeIndia

PRIMARY CHOICE

Speed: High · Customization: Medium

Reliable domestic suppliers with modest customization — the best all-round bet for the BYOB challenge.

Local Wholesalers

Speed: High · Customization: Low

Simple, standardized products when time is critical. Great for rapid testing and backup inventory.

Regional Hubs

Jaipur, Surat, Tiruppur · Customization: High

Category-specific and powerful — but really only if you have a local contact on the ground.

Manufacturer (direct)

AVOID FIRST ORDER

Speed: Low · Customization: High

Best for large orders with significant customization — not your first, small test batch.

HOW TO SEARCH INDIAMART LIKE A PRO

Approach discovery like a detective.

Use specific keywords

Search "canvas tote with zipper", not just "bags".

Filter by location

Prioritize your state/region to cut shipping time, cost and complexity.

Look for the "TrustSEAL"

It signals the supplier has passed basic background checks.

Read the business profile

Check GST registration, physical address, years in business, testimonials.

YOUR GOAL THIS PHASE

A shortlist of 5–7 high-quality suppliers.

The quality of your search shapes every step that follows. Invest time upfront to avoid costly mistakes later.

THE SUPPLIER VETTING CHECKLIST

Five boxes every supplier must tick.

1

Verified status

Has a TrustSEAL or is listed as a "Verified Supplier".

2

Physical address

A clear, specific address — not just a city name.

3

Authentic product photos

Their own actual products, not generic stock images.

4

Appropriate business type

Profile explicitly lists "Manufacturer" or "Wholesaler".

5

Professional web presence

Bonus: a basic website or detailed social presence.

THEN

Shortlist the **5–7** suppliers that meet these criteria, then move to outreach.

CONTACT & SAMPLING

One email that signals you're serious.

SAMPLE OUTREACH TEMPLATE

Subject: Inquiry for [Product Name] — New D2C Brand

Dear [Supplier],

We are a new D2C brand from [University Name]'s BYOB program launching a line of [brief product description]. Could you please share:

1. Minimum Order Quantity (MOQ)
2. Price per unit at MOQ
3. Sample cost & ordering process
4. Lead time for 50–100 units
5. Available customization options

We aim to place a test order within 10 days and are looking for a long-term supplier relationship.

Thank you,
[Your Name] · [Your Contact Information]

Be specific
Product details, quantities and timeline expectations.

Establish credibility
Mention your university program to add legitimacy.

Ask everything upfront
Saves time and shows professionalism.

Signal serious intent & follow up
State your ordering timeline; nudge politely after 24–48 hours.

Aim to narrow to 2–3 top candidates for sampling.

BUILDING TRUST WITH INDIAN SUPPLIERS

Suppliers reward a relationship, not a transaction.

THE TRANSACTIONAL APPROACH

What most people do

Send one email.

Negotiate only on price.

Disappear after the order.

THE RELATIONSHIP APPROACH

What you should do

Establish credibility
Mention the Mesa program.

Communicate regularly
Use WhatsApp for quick check-ins.

Visit if possible
One in-person visit beats 100 emails.

Negotiate flexibly
Focus on MOQs and lead times, not just price.

LET'S DO IT LIVE

A real call with a supplier.

Who wants to volunteer?

PRODUCT CATEGORY · PET PROTECTION WEAR

- Dog raincoats
- Dog shoes
- Dog T-shirts

THE ONE NON-NEGOTIABLE

Do not place a bulk order without a physical sample.



Financial protection

₹1,000 on a sample protects you from a **₹30,000+** mistake on a bulk order.

Quality verification

Photos mislead — a sample lets you judge material, construction and finish.

Supplier assessment

The process tests their communication, professionalism and reliability.

Marketing preparation

A real sample lets you shoot authentic content before inventory arrives.

YOUR PAPER SHIELD

Put every term in writing.

Product details

Description, quantity, colour, size, customization.

"50 units, cream canvas tote w/ zipper, 14"×16", black logo print"

Pricing

Per-unit price, total, and any extra costs.

"₹180 × 50 = ₹9,000 + ₹500 shipping = ₹9,500"

Payment terms

Paid now, balance due, and the method.

"50% advance ₹4,750 via UPI, balance before dispatch"

Timeline

Production time, dispatch date, delivery deadline.

"Production 7 days, dispatch by Jul 15, deliver by Jul 20"

Delivery info

Complete address with PIN code and contact details.

A written PO isn't bureaucracy — it's the record you point to when a shipment doesn't match what you agreed.

QUALITY CONTROL ON ARRIVAL

The first 24 hours decide everything.

1

Immediate inspection

Open the box on arrival; count every item against your PO.

2

Quality assessment

Check 20%+ for defects and correct specs — size, colour, material.

3

Documentation

Photograph any defects and damaged packaging as evidence.

4

Supplier communication

Report issues within 24h with photos; propose fair resolutions.

5

Secure storage

Store clean and organized; track inventory for fulfilment.

Most suppliers fix quality issues willingly — **but only if reported promptly with clear documentation.** Late complaints are met with resistance.

YOUR COMPLETE SOURCING ACTION PLAN

Ten days, three phases.

DAYS 1–3 · DISCOVERY

1. Finalize product specs and requirements.
2. Build a supplier shortlist with the vetting checklist.
3. Send professional outreach to 5–7 suppliers.

DAYS 4–7 · SAMPLE & SELECT

4. Evaluate responses; narrow to 2–3 candidates.
5. **Order physical samples** (highest priority).
6. Prepare a formal purchase-order template.

DAYS 8–10 · ORDER & RECEIVE

7. Place your order with a formal purchase order.
8. Track production; confirm dispatch over WhatsApp.
9. Inspect on arrival and run 24-hour quality control.

TROUBLESHOOTING 101

Spot the signs, run the play.

Supplier delays

Signs: missed deadlines, vague updates, late samples.

ACTION PLAN

1. Request a specific completion date.
2. Set daily check-ins via phone/WhatsApp.
3. Consider partial shipments.
4. Activate backup supplier if delay > 5 days.

Quality issues

Signs: doesn't match sample, defects, inconsistent finish.

ACTION PLAN

1. Document with detailed photos immediately.
2. Contact supplier within 24h with evidence.
3. Request partial refund or replacement.
4. Sort sellable from defective units.

Supplier goes silent

Signs: slow replies, dodged questions, missed callbacks.

ACTION PLAN

1. Switch channels — call, then WhatsApp.
2. Restate your order timeline and intent to buy.
3. Give a firm 48-hour deadline to respond.
4. Activate a backup supplier from your shortlist.

SOURCING MASTERY

Four things to remember.

01 Build local, buy local

India's own ecosystem is **faster**, lighter on capital and easier to fix.

02 The sample is non-negotiable

Never place a bulk order without a physical sample.

03 Vet before you commit

Verified status, a real address, and a relationship — not just the lowest price.

04 Use modern tools

IndiaMart's filters, TrustSEAL and business profiles make you look professional from day one.

YOUR TURN

Q&A

Bring me your sourcing dilemmas, your MOQ math, your supplier red flags.

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THANK YOU

Now go find your supplier.

You have the playbook. Build your shortlist, order the samples, and lock in a supplier you can trust.

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